An important thing to note about both human rights and civil rights is that they don't just limit the power of the central government; they also impose on it many active duties. It is not enough for a democratic government to abstain from infringing on human and civil rights. It must take actions to ensure them. For example, the right to life imposes on a democratic government the duty to protect citizens from criminal violence. If a government doesn't kill anyone, but also makes no effort to protect citizens from murder, this is anarchy rather than democracy.

THE PEOPLE VERSUS THE TRUTH

Of course, in every democracy there are lengthy discussions concerning the exact limits of human and civil rights. Even the right to life has limits. There are democratic countries like the United States that impose the death penalty, thereby denying some criminals the right to life. And every country allows itself the prerogative to declare war, thereby sending people to kill and be killed. So where exactly does the right to life end? There are also complicated and ongoing discussions concerning the list of rights that should be included in the two baskets. Who determined that freedom of religion is a basic human right? Should internet access be defined as a civil right? And what about animal rights? Or the rights of AI?

We cannot resolve these matters here. Both human and civil rights are intersubjective conventions that humans invent rather than discover, and they are determined by historical contingencies rather than universal reason. Different democracies can adopt somewhat different lists of rights. At least from the viewpoint of information flows, what defines a system as 'democratic' is only that its centre doesn't have unlimited authority and that the system possesses robust mechanisms to correct the centre's mistakes. Democratic networks assume that everyone is fallible, and that includes even the winners of elections and the majority of voters.

It is particularly crucial to remember that elections are *not* a method for discovering truth. Rather, they are a method for maintaining order by adjudicating between people's conflicting desires. Elections establish what the majority of people desire, rather than what the truth is. And people often desire the truth to be other than what it is. Democratic networks therefore